ADA / WCAG 2.1 AA Audit

Sites audited:

1. `https://aca-prod.accela.com/COSPRINGS/` — Accela Citizen Access portal
2. `https://coloradosprings.gov/policerecords` — CSPD Records Release page

Audit date: April 17, 2026 **Standard:** WCAG 2.1 Level AA (the target under DOJ Title II Final Rule, 28 CFR Part 35, effective April 24, 2026 for public entities of Colorado Springs' size) **Method:** Static structural audit of rendered HTML + DOM semantics. Does **not** include live color-contrast measurement, full keyboard traversal, screen-reader walkthrough, or PDF-level remediation review. Those require browser-based tooling and are noted where applicable.

Executive Summary

Site	Overall Risk	Likely Conformance	Priority
Accela Citizen Access	**HIGH**	Non-conformant	Urgent
coloradosprings.gov/policerecords	Moderate	Partial conformance	Address before deadline

The Accela portal is a significant liability. It relies on ASP.NET WebForms rendering patterns (layout tables, `__doPostBack` JavaScript-only navigation, `javascript:void(0)` pseudo-links) that fail multiple WCAG Level A success criteria — not AA, **A**, the floor. A motivated complainant could file a DOJ complaint on this site today and the city would have a very hard time defending it.

The coloradosprings.gov page is built on Drupal and shows evidence of accessibility awareness (skip link, breadcrumbs, semantic headings, dedicated Office of Accessibility page, language access page). Its issues are real but incremental — mostly content-level (duplicate headings, PDF forms, link context) rather than structural.

Legal Context (brief, relevant)

The April 2024 DOJ final rule under ADA Title II adopts WCAG 2.1 Level AA as the technical standard for state and local government web content and mobile apps. Compliance deadlines:

- Public entities with 50,000+ population: **April 24, 2026**
- Smaller entities / special districts: April 26, 2027

Colorado Springs (pop. ~490,000–500,000 depending on source) falls in the **earlier** cohort. Third-party content (i.e., Accela) is explicitly covered when the public entity uses it to offer services to the public — the city cannot disclaim responsibility by pointing at the vendor.

Site 1: Accela Citizen Access (`aca-prod.accela.com/COSPRINGS/`)

Structural findings

1. Layout tables everywhere (WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships — Level A, FAIL)

The landing page is built from deeply nested `<table>` elements used purely for visual arrangement — the department grid (Building, Police Records, Stormwater, Planning, Public Works, Neighborhood Services, Fire, Business Licensing) is rendered inside tables-within-tables-within-tables. Screen readers announce these as data tables with rows and columns, which is meaningless here and creates a hostile navigation experience. This is a 1990s pattern that modern frameworks eliminated 15+ years ago.

2. JavaScript-dependent navigation (WCAG 2.1.1 Keyboard — Level A, FAIL; 4.1.2 Name/Role/Value — Level A, FAIL)

Every department link is a `javascript:__doPostBack('ctl00$PlaceHolderMain$TabDataList...')` call. These:

- Are not real URLs, cannot be bookmarked or shared
- Do not expose a proper accessible name/role to assistive tech
- Break if JavaScript fails to load or is partially disabled
- Cannot be opened in a new tab via middle-click or right-click

The page even warns "Your browser does not support JavaScript" — but there is no non-JS fallback. The warning is just a string.

3. Browser-restriction statement (WCAG 4.1 Compatible — principle-level violation)

"For best results this site should be used via Chrome or Edge" — this is a red flag. It typically indicates the developer tested against two browsers and didn't bother with Safari, Firefox, or, critically, the screen-reader combinations (NVDA+Firefox, JAWS+Chrome, VoiceOver+Safari) that disabled users actually use. Stating it on-page also telegraphs to users that the vendor knows the site is fragile.

4. Ambiguous and repeated link text (WCAG 2.4.4 Link Purpose — Level A, FAIL)

Multiple links with the text `more`, `Search`, `[()]` appear without distinguishing context. Screen-reader users listing all links on the page hear a stream of "more, more, more, search,

search" with no way to tell them apart. The Announcements link literally renders as `[()]`.

5. Placeholder / broken hrefs (WCAG 2.4.4 — Level A, FAIL)

`Search` and `Search History` both link to `#`. These are dead anchors that do nothing but move focus to the top of the page. A keyboard user tabbing through will activate them and lose their place.

6. No visible `lang` attribute observed

WCAG 3.1.1 Language of Page (Level A) requires the primary language of the page be programmatically set (`<html lang="en">`). I cannot confirm from the rendered output whether this is set; if not, it is a failure.

7. Skip link present — partial credit

There is a "Skip Module Navigation" link pointing to `#FirstAnchorInACAMainContent`. This is the correct pattern. It only partially compensates because the thing it skips past is itself a mess of layout tables.

8. Heading hierarchy is non-semantic

The only visible `<h1>` on the page is "Message Bar" — which is a developer label, not user-meaningful content. The actual page welcome text ("Welcome to the City of Colorado Springs Citizen Access…") is presented in a table cell as body text, not as a heading. WCAG 2.4.6 Headings and Labels (Level AA) requires headings to describe topic or purpose.

9. Image alt text gaps

- `caret_arrow.gif` (the "more menu" indicator) appears to have no alternative text — likely decorative, should be `alt=""` or marked `aria-hidden`
- `loading.gif` has `"Please wait..."` which is acceptable for the loading indicator itself, but the pattern of using image-based UI feedback instead of an ARIA live region is dated

What you cannot tell without live testing

- Color contrast ratios (WCAG 1.4.3 AA)
- Focus visibility on keyboard tab (WCAG 2.4.7 AA)
- Whether forms deeper in the flow (permit applications, record requests) have proper `<label for="">` associations
- Whether error messages in forms are announced to screen readers (WCAG 3.3.1, 3.3.3)
- Session timeout handling (WCAG 2.2.1)
- Whether the PDF permit documents returned by the system are tagged/accessible

Based on the surface-level failures, I would expect the deeper forms to fail AA on most of these as well. Accela's Citizen Access has been the subject of accessibility complaints in multiple jurisdictions; the vendor has a VPAT but historical VPATs for this product describe it as "partially supports" across most criteria, which in plain language means "does not conform."

Severity summary for Site 1

- **Level A failures:** 5+ (structural, blocking for AT users)
- **Level AA failures:** Unknown but certain to include contrast and likely resize/reflow
- **Remediation path:** Cannot be fixed by the city directly. Options are (a) pressure Accela for a conformant release, (b) wrap the service in your own front-end that handles accessibility, (c) replace it. Your proposed platform is option (c), which is the right long-term answer.

Site 2: coloradosprings.gov/policerecords

Structural findings

1. Skip link present and correctly targeted

`Skip to main content` → `#main-content`. Implementation is standard and correct.

2. Semantic heading structure

H1 "Police Records Release Requests" is the page title. H2s organize sections ("Regular Police Records", "Colorado Springs Weekly", "GoCOS!", "Connect with @CityofCOS"). H3/H4 used for subsections. Hierarchy is sensible — no obvious skips.

3. Duplicate adjacent headings (minor, WCAG 1.3.1)

Several record-type sections render their H3 twice in immediate succession:

- "911/Radio Audio File" / "911/Radio Audio File"
- "Background (Local) Record Check" / "Background (Local) Record Check"
- "Body Worn Camera (BWC) Video" / "Body Worn Camera (BWC) Video"

This pattern suggests a collapsible-accordion component where both the accordion trigger and the revealed panel contain the same heading. Screen readers announce both, which is noisy but not a hard failure. Worth fixing.

4. Breadcrumb present

`City of Colorado Springs › City Departments › Police Department › Transparency, Records and Data › Records Release`. Good. Should verify it uses `<nav aria-label="Breadcrumb">` semantics — likely does given Drupal defaults.

5. Image alt text — mixed

- Logo image: `alt="Home"` — acceptable, functional link text
- Police badge: `alt="Colorado Springs Police Department badge officer"` — descriptive, appropriate
- GoCOS icon, App Store, Google Play — image-only links with alt text that describes function — fine

6. Link context — mostly good, one issue

Most links have clear, descriptive text ("Submit a Request", "Request for BWC Video", "Photo Records Request Form"). Two notable issues:

- The phrase `certain crimes` appears **three times as a link**, all pointing to the same PDF about victim's rights eligibility. Redundant but not wrong — screen-reader users will hear "certain crimes link" repeatedly.
- `Techdows` is a link to a 2015 third-party blog post explaining how to change the default PDF viewer in Windows 10. This is an external, aging, and fragile reference that the city should not be directing users to. Separately, the link does not signal it opens an external site.

7. PDF-dependent workflows (WCAG 1.1.1, 1.3.1 for the PDFs themselves)

Several records processes route users to PDF forms:

- `BWC request form (2026).pdf`
- `Records ID - Photo Request Form.pdf`
- `vra_records_requests_info-042518.pdf`
- `Steps to Request Online Through Accela.pdf`

PDF accessibility is its own audit. Under the Title II rule, PDFs posted after the compliance date must conform to WCAG 2.1 AA (which in practice means PDF/UA tagging, reading-order, alt text on images, form field labels, language declaration). A 2018 document (`042518`) predates current accessibility expectations and is almost certainly untagged. **I'd recommend a separate PDF audit pass** — tools like PAC 2024 or Adobe Acrobat's accessibility checker will surface issues quickly.

8. Translation affordance

The `[Translate]` link targets a Google Translate widget, with a separate "Google Translate Disclaimer" in the footer. Google Translate is an accessibility *assist* for Limited English Proficiency users but is not a substitute for Title VI Language Access obligations — which the city separately links to (`TitleVILanguageAccess`). Structurally sound.

9. Form-free page — lower risk

This page itself hosts no interactive forms; it's essentially a directory page pointing to Accela (see Site 1) and to PDFs. The page's own AA risk is therefore low; the risk is entirely in what it sends users to.

10. Footer: Accessibility and non-discrimination linked

`Web Accessibility` → Office of Accessibility / Accessible IT page `Non-Discrimination` → Title II notice `Accessibility` (in header) → TitleIIADA

Presence of a Title II notice and a dedicated Office of Accessibility is a positive indicator and also a legal requirement under the existing ADA Title II regulations.

What you cannot tell without live testing

- Color contrast of the CSPD red header, alert banners, and footer links
- Focus indicator visibility on keyboard tab
- Weather widget ("Now 46° / High 47° / Low 36°") — whether dynamically updated content is announced to AT
- Alert banner ("Burn Restrictions now in effect") — whether this uses `role="alert"` or a live region, and whether it's dismissible via keyboard
- Behavior of the accordion/collapsible sections (the duplicate-heading pattern suggests these exist)
- Mobile menu button — whether `aria-expanded` is managed correctly

Severity summary for Site 2

- **Level A failures:** 0–2 (depending on accordion implementation and PDF accessibility)
- **Level AA failures:** Likely a handful, resolvable at the theme/component level
- **Remediation path:** Normal Drupal accessibility work. Manageable in-house.

Combined Recommendations

Immediate (before April 24 deadline):

1. Add a public accessibility statement linking both sites, including the Accela portal, with a feedback mechanism and known-issues disclosure. Title II requires this regardless; it also reduces legal exposure because it demonstrates good-faith effort.

2. Commission a formal VPAT/ACR from Accela for the Citizen Access module currently deployed. If the vendor cannot produce one dated within the last 12 months, escalate contractually.
3. Run the coloradosprings.gov/policerecords page through axe DevTools and WAVE. Fix the accordion duplicate-heading pattern and any contrast failures that surface.
4. Audit the top 5–10 most-downloaded PDFs on the page (BWC form, Photo Request form, VRA notice, Accela-steps guide, Schedule of Fees) for PDF/UA tagging. Re-issue the ones that fail.

Medium-term:

5. Treat the Accela portal as an accessibility *and* UX liability, not just a vendor product. The structural failures are not fixable by the city — they are intrinsic to the product's rendering approach.
6. For any new citizen-facing module (record request, permit, public comment), build to WCAG 2.1 AA from day one. Test with real screen readers, not just automated tools.

Strategic — connects to your platform brief:

Your proposed "civic Jira" is the right architectural answer to the Accela problem specifically. Three accessibility advantages baked into your design:

- **Ticket-on-parcel model with plain-language output** maps directly to WCAG 3.1.5 Reading Level (AAA, but strongly aligned with plain-language civic tech principles). If every ticket has an AI-generated plain-language summary, you have a native accessibility feature — not a retrofit.
- **"Progression trail" and "status tracking"** are naturally addressable via ARIA live regions and status pages. Accela's `__doPostBack` pattern makes status updates invisible to AT; a modern React/Vue/HTMX front-end with proper live regions makes them audible by default.
- **"Property card" public layer** — if a citizen can look up a parcel and receive a structured, semantic, plain-language summary of everything attached to it, that is a superior accessibility outcome to any PDF-driven workflow, full stop.

One thing to design in from the start: **every ticket must be reachable by a permanent, shareable URL** (not a session-bound JavaScript postback). Accela's biggest structural failure is that it doesn't let you link to anything. Your platform should treat URL-addressability as a first-class requirement. It helps SEO, helps accessibility, helps the plain-language notification layer, and helps anyone — disabled or not — actually share a record with a neighbor or a journalist.

Limitations of this audit

This is a static audit based on rendered HTML from a single page fetch of each site, on April 17, 2026. It does not constitute a legal opinion, a full WCAG conformance evaluation, or a substitute for user testing with people who use assistive technology. A defensible audit for Title II purposes should include:

- Automated scans (axe-core, WAVE, Lighthouse, Pa11y) across representative page templates
- Manual keyboard-only traversal
- Screen-reader testing (minimum: NVDA+Firefox, JAWS+Chrome, VoiceOver+Safari on macOS and iOS)
- Mobile testing (TalkBack on Android, VoiceOver on iOS)
- Form-level testing in Accela with real submissions
- PDF-level testing against PDF/UA-1 (ISO 14289-1)

Estimated effort for a full audit of both properties: 40–60 hours for a qualified accessibility specialist. Budget accordingly.